

**FITNESSWISE**

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STORIES

NAVIGATING THE BIG JOB EFFECTIVELY

While taking up a new coaching role, avoiding common mistakes ensures a smoother transition and a **positive impact** at the new place.

Whether you are a young S&C coach or a seasoned veteran, a high-performance coach, or an assistant, there are common mistakes to avoid when starting a new job:

1. Changing too much, too quickly

It's important to plan and prioritise any changes that need to be made. Introducing new processes and protocols should be done in a phased manner, aligned with the team's and players' needs while considering the philosophy of the management. People often struggle with rapid changes, so it's wise to be certain about when and how changes are implemented. Not everything needs to change overnight.

2. Always needing to be right

An old quote goes — 'Knowledge is knowing that a tomato is a fruit, but wisdom is not putting it in a fruit salad'. Just because coaches know more than their athletes doesn't make them wise. Being right doesn't always mean they're being prudent. They don't have to win every argument or get their way all the time. There's a difference between being right and doing what's right. It's no fun being around a know-it-all coach.

3. Enforcing too many rules

While rules are necessary, too many can be counterproductive. Coaches might find themselves spending more time enforcing rules than actually coaching. Rules often come with punishments, and the more rules there are, the more punishments need to be enforced. It's crucial to be judicious in setting rules.

The best coaches lead with a combination of logic, wisdom, and empathy. They see the big picture and understand the current situation. For example, an athlete arriving late because they were smoking with friends is different from one who was delayed due to traffic on their way to the gym. The rules and punishments should account for these differences.

Coaches need to be thoughtful about the rules they set. While rules are necessary, the standards they reinforce and promote daily are more important. It's more crucial to focus on catching others doing good than on catching them breaking a long list of rules.

4. Lack of planning

Having only short-term vision is like being blind. Yes, there is a need to make every team as good as possible. Too many S&C coaches fall into the vicious cycle of taking shortcuts and scrambling to improve the team due to poor past decisions. They mortgage the future for the present, especially in less-than-ideal situations.

The best S&C coaches view planning like a chess game, thinking many steps ahead and seeing the whole board rather than focusing only on their next move in a myopic manner. Seeing the entire forest, not just one tree, is crucial.

Planning is the foundation for proper execution, with a deep understanding of core principles.

5. Favouring influential players

Some coaches focus too much on training captains or influential players, neglecting the development of future players and leaving other staff members out of the loop. This short-changes the current team's